

Dry Kadai Paneer

Ingredients

Main Ingredients

- Paneer – **400 g** (cut into 1-inch cubes)
- Onion – **3 medium** (cut into cubes/petals)
- Capsicum – **2 medium** (cut into cubes)
- Tomato – **2 medium** (finely chopped)
- Garlic – **12 cloves** (finely chopped)
- Ginger – **1½ inch piece** (grated)
- Oil or ghee – **3 tbsp**
- Salt – **1¼ tsp**
- Coriander leaves – **¼ cup chopped**
- Lemon – **1 whole**

Fresh Kadai Masala (Most Important)

- Coriander seeds – **3 tbsp**
- Cumin seeds – **1½ tsp**
- Black peppercorns – **1 tsp**
- Dry red chilies – **4 to 5**

Additional Spice Powders

- Turmeric – **¼ tsp**
 - Kashmiri red chili powder – **1 tsp**
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Step 1: Roast and Make Kadai Masala

1. Heat a pan on **low flame**.
2. Add:
 - 3 tbsp coriander seeds
 - 1½ tsp cumin seeds
 - 1 tsp peppercorns
 - 4–5 dry red chilies
3. Roast for **2–3 minutes** until aromatic.
4. Let them cool completely.
5. Crush coarsely using a mixer or mortar and pestle.

Do not make a fine powder.

The coarse texture gives authentic kadai paneer flavor.

Step 2: Lightly Roast Paneer

1. Heat **1 tbsp oil** in a pan.
2. Add paneer cubes.
3. Roast for **2 minutes** on medium flame.
4. Turn gently and roast another **2 minutes**.

The paneer should be lightly golden, not hard.

Remove and keep aside.

Step 3: Prepare the Masala

1. In the same pan add remaining **2 tbsp oil**.
2. Add chopped garlic.
3. Fry for **30 seconds**.
4. Add grated ginger.
5. Fry for another **30 seconds**.

The aroma should become strong and pleasant.

Step 4: Cook Onions

1. Add cubed onions.
2. Cook on medium flame for **4–5 minutes**.
3. Stir occasionally.

The onions should become slightly golden but remain a little crunchy.

Step 5: Add Tomatoes

1. Add chopped tomatoes.
2. Add:
 - $\frac{1}{4}$ tsp turmeric
 - 1 tsp Kashmiri chili powder

- 1¼ tsp salt
3. Cook for **5–7 minutes**.

Keep stirring until:

- Tomatoes become soft.
 - Water evaporates.
 - The mixture becomes thick.
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Step 6: Add Fresh Kadai Masala

1. Add the freshly crushed kadai masala.
2. Mix thoroughly.
3. Cook for **2 minutes**.

Your kitchen should now smell like restaurant-style kadai paneer.

Step 7: Add Capsicum

1. Add cubed capsicum.
2. Stir-fry for **3–4 minutes**.

Do not overcook.

Capsicum should remain slightly crunchy.

Step 8: Add Paneer

1. Add roasted paneer cubes.
2. Toss gently so all cubes are coated with masala.
3. Cook for **3–4 minutes**.

If any moisture remains, continue cooking for another minute until the dish becomes dry.

Step 9: Finish

1. Turn off the flame.
 2. Add chopped coriander leaves.
 3. Squeeze juice from **1 lemon**.
 4. Mix gently.
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Final Result

You will get:

- Soft paneer cubes
- Slightly crunchy onions and capsicum
- Thick masala coating
- No gravy
- Perfect for chapati

For the best taste, serve immediately with hot chapatis. The freshly roasted coriander seeds are the secret that makes dry kadai paneer taste much better than ordinary paneer fry. 😊🍴